Neobank Sprint

Sprint simulation • 6 phases per sprint • one device per group

Your group runs a neobank for several sprints. You plan, build, get hit by an incident, release, and watch the regulator react. Most customers at the end wins — if you can still ship by then.

The three rolls. Develop: d20 + Dev ≥ the summed targets of everything you picked, plus legacy drag — all or nothing. Mitigate: d20 + Mit ≥ the incident's target. Release: d20 + Rel – bugs – 2 per buggy feature ≥ the summed release targets; miss it and everything soft-launches at 25%.

The six phases of a sprint

#	PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS
01	**Sprint Planning**	Each group picks features up to its capacity, then commits.
02	**Development**	One d20 per group against the combined target. All or nothing.
03	**Incident**	One card. It hits every group, but not equally.
04	**Release**	Built is not shipped. Bugs tax every release roll.
05	**Market Event**	The world reacts to the portfolio you have actually built.
06	**Retro & Investment**	Two points, three for a sprint handled well. They do not carry over.

Two kinds of debt

	BUGS	AUDIT FINDINGS
Earned by	Pushing unfinished work through	Failed incidents and regulatory cards
Taxes	Every Release roll	Every Mitigation roll
Hard wall	5 bugs → nothing ships at all	3 findings → one slot less capacity
Cleared by	Automated Testing, or a slot (–2)	Compliance by Design, or a slot (–1)

The table, and what a slot can buy

Six cards each sprint: three product, three platform. One of each rotates off at the end of the sprint, whether or not anyone took it, so a card is available for exactly three sprints.

Two slots a sprint, three with Cross-Functional Team, one fewer while you hold three open findings. Taking no new work is always allowed. The two migration cards cost three slots on their own — they are the whole sprint, and they stay off the table until the third slot can exist.

A slot does not have to go on a feature. In planning you may spend one on **remediation** instead: one slot clears two bugs, or one audit finding. It takes effect at the start of Development, before the release roll — so at five bugs, one slot gets you shipping again in the same sprint.

Miss the Development roll and you decide per card: **push it through** (built and released, plus a bug) or **shelve it**. A shelved card goes on your shelf: from the next sprint you can pick it from there, even after it has left the table, at **half its Dev target**, rounded up. Full slots, and it stays on the shelf until it is built or pushed through.

Investment points

Every retro pays **two**. From sprint 3 it pays a **third** if the sprint handled its incident — rolled against it and won, or built the card that removes it — or ended with no bugs. Only one extra point, however well both went.

> **Points do not carry over.** Whatever is not spent at the retro is gone when the next sprint starts, so the three-point practices are only within reach in a sprint that earned the bonus.

Legacy drag

One platform card carries two product features. Every product feature past that adds +1 to your combined Development target, up to +6. Platform cards earn few customers and pay a permanent modifier instead, capped at +4 in each of Dev, Rel and Mit. The bug counter models unfinished work; legacy drag models the architecture you never built.

Agile practices

Bought with Investment Points at the retro. Permanent, and they compound.

PRACTICE	COST	SESSION	EFFECT
Pair Programming	**2 IP**	7	+2 on every Development roll.
Automated Testing	**2 IP**	6	Clears 1 bug each retro. +3 against dependency incidents.
CI/CD Pipeline	**2 IP**	8	+3 on every Release roll.
Definition of Done	**3 IP**	7	Pushed-through features no longer create bugs.
Feature Flags	**2 IP**	9	Shelved features still earn 20% of their reward.
Modular Architecture	**2 IP**	3	Picking 2+ features lowers the combined Dev target by 3.
Observability & SRE	**2 IP**	9	+2 on Mitigation. Outages no longer hit you harder.
Agentic Coding	**3 IP**	5	+3 on Development — but pushing through costs 2 bugs, not 1.
Blameless Postmortems	**1 IP**	9	+3 on Mitigation rolls.
Retro Culture	**3 IP**	7	+1 on every roll you make.
Cross-Functional Team	**3 IP**	7	One more feature slot per sprint.
Compliance by Design	**2 IP**	10	Clears 1 audit finding each retro.

Product cards

15 cards • customers now, nothing permanent

CARD	KIND	DEV	REL	USERS	COST	WHAT IT IS
Crypto Custody	growth	15	14	**30k**	2	High reward, high scrutiny. Ask the regulator first.
Robo-Advisor	growth	14	13	**26k**	2	Suitability questionnaire, model portfolios, MiFID paperwork.
SEPA Instant Payments	core	13	12	**22k**	2	Ten-second settlement, 24/7/365. No maintenance window.
Mobile App Redesign	growth	8	11	**20k**	1	The thing customers actually judge you on.
FX & Multi-Currency	growth	12	11	**19k**	2	Interbank rates with a transparent markup.
Card Issuing	core	11	10	**18k**	2	Virtual and physical debit cards on a scheme BIN.
Merchant Payouts	core	12	11	**17k**	2	Same-day settlement for business customers.
Savings Pots	growth	7	9	**14k**	1	Sub-accounts with goals and round-ups.
Real-Time Notifications	growth	6	8	**11k**	1	Push within a second of authorisation.
KYC Onboarding	compliance	9	7	**10k**	1	Identity verification before the first euro moves.
PSD2 Open Banking API	compliance	10	9	**9k**	1	Account information and payment initiation for third parties.
Fraud Detection	compliance	12	8	**8k**	2	Real-time scoring on the authorisation path.
Strong Customer Auth	compliance	9	8	**6k**	1	Two factors, dynamic linking, PSD2 Article 97.
AML Monitoring	compliance	11	7	**5k**	1	Transaction surveillance and suspicious-activity reports.
Privacy & GDPR Controls	compliance	8	6	**4k**	1	Consent, retention, erasure. Pays nothing until it pays everything.

Platform cards

24 cards • few customers, permanent leverage • the number is the lecture it comes from

CARD	S	DEV	REL	USERS	COST	PERMANENT	WHAT IT IS
Core Ledger	1	12	8	6k	2	—	Double-entry bookkeeping. Every balance in the bank derives from it.
Database Sharding	2	13	7	5k	2	**Mit +1**	Partition the ledger by customer range. Writes stop fighting each other.
Data Pipeline	2	12	7	6k	2	**Rel +1**	Streaming ingestion, not a nightly batch and a prayer. Everything downstream gets fresher.
Data Warehouse	2	10	5	3k	2	**Mit +1**	Dull, cheap, and the only place the regulator's numbers reconcile.
Caching Layer	2	9	6	5k	1	**Rel +1**	Balance reads served from memory instead of hammering the core.
Performance Profiling	2	9	6	4k	1	**Rel +1**	Find the query that costs you the p99 instead of guessing at it.
Microservice Migration	3	14	8	7k	3	**Rel +2**	Break the monolith so two teams stop queueing behind one deploy.
Disaster Recovery	3	12	6	2k	2	**Mit +1**	Second region, tested failover, documented RTO.
API Gateway	3	11	7	5k	2	**Rel +1**	One edge for auth, routing and versioning instead of twelve.
Core Banking Migration	4	16	9	12k	3	**Dev +1 Rel +1**	Off the legacy mainframe. The one everybody postpones.
Test Automation Suite	6	10	6	3k	2	**Dev +1 Rel +1**	A suite that runs on every commit and actually gets read when it fails.
A/B Testing System	6	10	8	9k	2	**Rel +1**	Ship to five percent first and find out before everyone sees it.
Code Quality Gates	6	9	5	2k	1	**Dev +2**	Coverage, linting and review rules enforced by the pipeline, not by asking nicely.
Error Tracking	6	8	5	3k	1	**Mit +1**	Exceptions aggregated and attributed instead of scrolling a log.
Documentation Wiki	7	6	4	2k	1	**Dev +1**	Decisions written down where the next person will look for them.
Containerization	8	10	6	3k	2	**Dev +1 Rel +1**	The same image in dev, staging and production. No more works-on-my-machine.
Security Audit Log	8	9	5	3k	1	**Mit +1**	Tamper-evident record of who touched which account. The supervisor will ask.
Rate Limiting	8	7	5	3k	1	**Mit +1**	Per-client quotas on the public API. The cheapest abuse defence there is.
Observability Stack	9	10	5	3k	1	**Mit +2**	Traces, metrics, structured logs. Nobody asks for it.
Backup & Recovery	9	9	5	2k	1	**Mit +1**	Point-in-time restore that somebody has actually tested this year.
Service Monitoring	9	8	5	3k	1	**Mit +1**	Health checks and alerting, so the customer is not your monitoring.
Load Balancer	9	8	5	4k	1	**Mit +1**	Spread the traffic and drain a node without an outage.
Incident Runbooks	9	7	4	2k	1	**Mit +2**	Written, rehearsed, and findable at three in the morning.
CDN Integration	9	7	5	6k	1	**Rel +1**	Static assets close to the customer. The app stops feeling slow abroad.

Incidents

12 cards • one a sprint • it hits every group, but not equally

INCIDENT	TARGET	WHAT MOVES THE ROLL	IF YOU FAIL
Payday Peak Outage	**12**	Observability avoids –3; Caching or Sharding +3	–10% customers, +1 bug
Data Breach	**14**	Privacy & GDPR +2; Security Audit Log +2	–26% (–14% with Privacy), +2 findings
Lead Engineer Resigns	**–**	Pair Programming or Documentation Wiki removes it	–3 on this sprint's Dev roll
BaFin Spot Audit	**13**	AML Monitoring +3; Security Audit Log +2	+2 audit findings
Card Scheme Mandate	**11**	CI/CD Pipeline +3	releases blocked this sprint
Fraud Ring	**12**	Fraud Detection removes it; Rate Limiting +3	–13%, +1 finding
Cloud Region Failure	**13**	Disaster Recovery removes it; Backup +3, Load Balancer +1	–16% customers
Critical Dependency CVE	**12**	Automated Testing or Test Suite +3; Gates +1; Containers +1	+2 bugs
Instant Payment SLA Breach	**12**	only hits you if you shipped SEPA Instant	–12%, +1 finding
Blame Storm	**–**	Blameless Postmortems removes it	–1 Investment Point
Regulatory Reporting Deadline	**11**	Data Warehouse removes it; Data Pipeline +3	+1 finding, –5%
Customer Phishing Wave	**12**	Strong Customer Auth +4; Rate Limiting +2	–9% customers

Market events

One a sprint, resolved against what each group has actually built. Gains are fixed amounts; losses are a share of the customers you already have, so they grow with you.

EVENT	PAYS	COSTS
DORA Comes Into Force	Disaster Recovery → +12k	otherwise –10%, +1 finding
GDPR Enforcement Wave	Privacy & GDPR → +8k	otherwise –16%
Instant Payments Regulation	SEPA Instant → +15k	otherwise –9%
Funding Winter	—	leader –14%, everyone else –7%
App Store Feature Spot	the leader → +13k	—
MiCA Licensing Round	Crypto Custody → +18k	—
Central Bank Raises Rates	Savings Pots → +14k	otherwise –5%
Open Banking Breakthrough	PSD2 API → +11k	—
Reviewer Tests Every Neobank	fewest bugs → +12k	otherwise –4% per bug
Incumbent Price War	Mobile App → only –2%	otherwise –12%
Consumer Trust Index	no findings → +9k	1–2 → –5%, three or more → –15%
Latency Benchmark Published	two of CDN / Caching / Profiling → +12k, one → +3k	none → –10%
Engineering Brand	two of Wiki / Gates / Test Suite → +2k and +1 IP	—

Sprint tracker

Your console keeps the real numbers • this is for the debrief

Fill it in as you go, so you can point at the sprint where it turned.

SPRINT	PICKED	DEV ROLL	INCIDENT	RELEASED	CUSTOMERS	BUGS	FINDINGS	BOUGHT
1								
2								
3								
4								
5								
6								
7								
8								

Adapted from the CatTube sprint game, itself inspired by the “Agile 101” board game by Emma Hopkinson-Spark (101 Ways).